

T H E
P R O V I N C E
O F
M I D W I V E S
I N T H E

Practice of their ART:

Instructing them in the timely Knowledge of such
Difficulties as require the Assistance of MEN,

For the Preservation of

M O T H E R and C H I L D.

Very necessary for the Perusal of ALL the SEX
interested in the Subject,

And interspersed with some

New and Useful OBSERVATIONS.

By WILLIAM CLARK, M. D.

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Title: The Province of Midwives in the Practice of their Art

Author: William Clark

Release date: May 16, 2016 [eBook #52086]

Most recently updated: October 23, 2024

Language: English

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/52086

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE PROVINCE
OF MIDWIVES IN THE PRACTICE OF THEIR ART ***

The Province of Midwives in
the Practice of their Art, by
William Clark, M. D. 1698–
ca. 1780.

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And of the College of PHYSICIANS.

—————*Molliter Auf*er Onus. OVID. FASTI.

Printed for *William Frederick*, in BATH; and sold by *M. Cooper*, in *Pater-Noster-Row*,
LONDON.

MDCCLI.

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ADVERTISEMENT TO THE READER.

***T**H E following small Tract will appear contemptible to those who judge of the Worth of Books by their Bulk; but the Author believes such as are practis'd in Midwifry will acknowledge both the Want and Usefulness of an Essay of this Kind.*

The Division of the Chapters, naturally arising from the various Circumstances which are treated of, will rather assist than burden the Memory, and admit of a ready Recourse to the short Instructions, in the Knowledge and Practice absolutely necessary, given under each Head.

The Reader will the more readily excuse any Defect in the Stile, when he considers the Necessity of a strict Expression on the Subject and the Difficulty a Man lies under, who writes not to the learned and experienced, but chiefly for the Sake of Persons ignorant in Anatomy and Philosophy, on a Subject which for the most Part excludes Information by Sight.

On such a Subject it will not be imagined Vanity or Applause can incline a Man to write a Pamphlet, rather than a Volume; when the Author is not

conscious of having omitted the Instruction to be found in any Book extant, within the Limits of his Design; and hopes Experience will teach its Value both to Midwives and Matrons; and that the Perusal will not at all injure, if it does not improve, the most knowing and experienced.

The READER is desir'd to correct the following ERRORS with the Pen.

P AGE 9, Line 16, *read* Pains about the Back, Navel, &c. —P. 33, l. 12. omit the Period after the Word Pain; and make a Semicolon, instead of the Comma, after touch'd it.

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CHAPTER I.

The DESIGN.

THE Case of *Child-bearing* Women is very lamentable, in the Country especially, by Reason of the Ignorance and Unskilfulness of *Midwives*; for by their Negligence and perverse Management, many Mothers and Children are destroyed, to the great Misfortune of particular Families, as well as of the *Publick*, at a Time when it suffers by the Loss of useful Hands, from too many other Causes. It were therefore to be wished, that all *Midwives* were so far apprised of their Duty, as to be able to distinguish between Cases within their Abilities, and such Difficulties as may occasion the Loss of the Mother, or Child, or both, for Want of necessary Assistance.

They who intend to practice Midwifry in PARIS, are oblig'd to attend *anatomical* Lectures and *Dissections*, that their Judgments may be inform'd, by the Knowledge of the Structure of the Body, for an Undertaking so hazardous in ignorant Hands.

London, at present, affords equal Advantages of Information; for the *anatomical* Wax-work, with suitable Lectures, might furnish as good a Qualification, with less Offence than real Dissections; and there are not wanting those who professedly instruct both Sexes by *mechanical Demonstrations*.

And for the future, it is to be hoped, there will be no Necessity for Men to have Recourse to PARIS for *Observation*, since we have *Infirmaries* at

Home for the Accommodation of Women in Child-bed; and tho' they are expos'd naked to the Eye in the *Hotel de Dieu*, it must be confess'd, that the fundamental Rules of the *Art* are not built on what the Eye of the Observer can possibly discover in the most expert *Operators*; but depend on Circumstances conceal'd from Sight, within the Body of the Patient.

But whatever Advantages LONDON and WESTMINSTER afford for the Instruction of Midwives, the Country is entirely destitute of them; and the best Books on the Subject, adorn'd with elegant Figures, can give but a very imperfect Notion of the Parts they represent, to any who have not attended *Dissections*, or seen more natural *Resemblances* than Cuts.

The Figures in Books, exhibit the *Bones* of the *Pelvis*, a Variety of *Situations* of the Infant, and *Uterus*, the Placenta and umbilical Vessels and Membranes, &c. whereas it would be no less serviceable to those, who assist Women in Travel, to be acquainted with the Viscera, liable to suffer by a difficult Labour; for the *Liver*, *Spleen*, *Sweetbread* and *Kidneys*, if not the principal Contents of the Chest, may be so injured by the ill *Position* of the Child, Compression of the Parts, and rash Assistance, as to prove fatal, more or less immediately; occasioning *Inflammations*, *Suppurations*, *Mortifications*, *Schirrhu's*, *Cancers*, or *Consumptions*.

The best Writers of Midwifry, such as *Mauriceau*, *Deventer*, *De la Motte*, *Heister* and others, explain the Causes of difficult Births, and the proper Methods of Assistance; but instead of improving most *Country* Midwives, fill them with Conceits of what, it is impossible, they should understand, and thereby occasion the Loss of great Numbers of Women and Children.

In order therefore that Midwives may acquit themselves with Reputation, and that *Child-bearing* Women may be the better Judges for themselves, or the charitable Part of the Sex, who are past these Dangers, the better able to assist their Friends and Neighbours, I shall endeavour to shew how far they may act with Safety under the Disadvantage of Country Practice, and

describe those Symptoms, which for the most Part accompany hard Labours, very probably beyond their Abilities; when they will justly incur the Censure of Inhumanity and Rashness to depend upon their own Skill.

CHAPTER II.

IN this Chapter I have avoided the Use of Terms of Art, or explain'd them, in Regard to those for whom I chiefly write, as far as my Regard to Decency admits; but if any Word should occur not easily understood by any of my Readers, almost any *English* Dictionary will explain its Meaning; and it cannot be expected that any Book can instruct those who cannot read, tho' I am sorry to say too many such assume the Office of *Midwives*.

As Curiosity may reasonably induce many of the Sex concern'd in the Subject of these Sheets, to be inform'd of somewhat of the Provision supreme Wisdom has made for the Existence of Children in the Womb, I shall briefly mention the most obvious *Instruments* relating to their Breeding and Birth, without puzzling my Readers with minute *anatomical* Descriptions.

The Vagina, or Passage, lies between the Neck of the *Bladder* and the large or strait Gut; it is connected at the inward extreme to the *Womb*, and called the *outward Orifice* at its beginning.

The *Womb* lies between the *Bladder* and *Strait Gut*, and is connected to both; during the Time of *Breeding* it increases in its *Dimensions*, and rising higher in the Body, by Reason of the Weight and Substance of it, with its

Contents, at the Fund, or remote End of it, may be liable to swag too much *forward* or *backward*, or incline more or less to either Side, especially in such, as by their Occasions of Industry in Life are obliged to a Variety of *indirect* Situations; by which Means the *inward* Orifice is perverted from a *direct Site* with Respect to the Passage, and obstructs an easy Exclusion of the Infant in Travel.

The *Placenta* or *After-birth*, adhering to the *Fund* of the *Womb*, receives the *Mother's* Blood, by the *Umbilical-Vessels*, or *Navel-String*, conveys it to the Child for its Nourishment, and retransmits what is superfluous; maintaining by the Intercourse of *Arteries* and *Veins*, the Circulation of the Blood between Mother and Child.

The *Membranes* closely connected to the *Placenta*, and the *Fund* of the *Womb*, between both which they seem to take their Rise, contain the *Humours* in which the Infant swims, the better to preserve it from Injuries, by its Pressure against *unyielding* Parts, and the *Humours* before, and after the *Breaking* of the *Membranes*, commonly call'd the *Breaking of the Waters*, in the Birth, very much facilitate it, by opening the *inward Orifice* of the *Womb*, and lubricating the *Passage* for the Child: These *Membranes* come away with the *Placenta*, under the Name of the *After-birth*, or *Secundines*, indifferently.

The *Pelvis* or *Bason*, wherein the *Uterus* or *Womb* is seated, is form'd by the *forward* Bones, commonly call'd the *Share-Bone*, the *Hip-Bones* and their Continuation on each Side, and the lower Part of the *Back-Bone*, all which are so contiguous to each other, as to form this Cavity, generally much larger in Women than Men, cloathed with Muscles, between which the *Vagina* is inserted.

The right Formation of the *Pelvis*, is of the greatest Consequence in Favour of an *easy* Birth; when the *Bones* forming it, *forward* and *backward*, and on *each* Side, both above and below, don't too much

approach each other, and prevent the Exclusion of the Child between, by a free Admission.

CHAPTER III.

The Symptoms preceeding Natural Labours.

I SHALL pass over the Symptoms of Pregnancy, and the Distinctions of true and false Conceptions, as Things of which Midwives can seldom be expected to be *proper* Judges, and proceed to their Business, *Natural Labours*; comprehending, under this Name, all such Cases, which require no further Assistance than *Midwives*, in a general Way, may easily give; or in their Absence a Nurse, or any sensible Woman, who has attended Deliveries.

After the Woman has gone her due Time of Nine Months, the most usual Term; the Signs preceeding Labour are Pains about the Back, Navel and Loins; a considerable Falling of the Tumour of the Belly, by the Burden's sinking lower; and incommoding the Woman in walking; a more frequent Inclination to make Water: These Symptoms increase in Proportion as the Birth approaches; but as the most certain Knowledge of *natural* Births, can only be obtained by *Touching* the Woman in Labour, after having premised some Things concerning her *proper* Situation; I shall direct how it ought to be done.

CHAPTER IV.

Of SITUATION.

MANY in the Country choose to be on their *Legs* or *Knees*, supported by a Woman on each Side, or *lean* on a Chair or Bed, and pass well enough through the present Scene of their Miseries: But I would preferably advise a Posture between *lying* and *sitting*, on a *Pallet* or *common* Bed, the *Head* and *Shoulders* being *rais'd* by Bolsters or Pillows, the Feathers *beat back* from the Bed's Feet, to support the hollow of the Loins, and prevent the Pressure of any Thing against the *Bottom* of the Back Bone, to obstruct the Passage of the Child.

This *Situation* is most commodious, during Labour, for a Woman to *assist* her Pains with the greater Freedom of Respiration, and the least Fatigue and Expence of Spirits; especially if the *labouring* Woman lay hold of a *folded* Napkin, held stiffly for that Purpose, drawing her Feet *upwards* towards her Seat, *separating* her Knees, and *fixing* her Feet against something that will not easily give Way.

If the Person in Labour will not be in Bed, the End may be answered by her *sitting* in *another's* Lap, with the *Bottom* of her Back-Bone situate

between the other's Knees, with her *own* separated and supported, and Feet fixed as aforesaid, to favour her bearing down.

'Tis inconsistent with the Design of my Writing to describe all the *convenient* Situations, necessary in Cases of Difficulty, yet when the Operator has rectified all Obstructions to the Birth, the same Situation of the Body upon a *Slope*, from the Head downwards is most suitable, even altho', for Conveniency, she should be deliver'd lying on one Side.

I shall, on this Occasion, observe, what I have found Advantageous in my own Experience, as well as consonant to the Advice of the best Writers on the Subject: That the Delivery on the *Back*, by the Assistance of one placed on *each Side*, supporting her by the *Hams*, with her Knees *separated*, and raising her *Back Bone* a little from the Bed during the *Activity* of Pains, and the *Midwife's Assistance* of either Sex, is vastly preferable to the Delivery on *one Side*, to which I impute the Loss of many Children brought by *Turning*, as well as a more *tedious* Labour in other Cases; because this Posture, in some Degree, *contracts* the *Passage*, and only admits the proper Separation of *one* Knee.

CHAPTER V.

Concerning TOUCHING.

THIS ought to be put in Practice, as soon as, from the Symptoms given in the Third Chapter, it is reasonable to expect the Birth approaching; and a *Child-bearing* Person would be very much her own Enemy to refuse the only Means of giving a *true* Information of her Case, and the Knowledge how to do her the most effectual Service.

The Midwife, having her Nails well pared, and very smooth, and her Fingers anointed with Oil or Lard, must introduce the two *fore Fingers* of either Hand into the *Passage* or *Neck* of the *Womb*, as far as its *inward* Orifice, directing them with a *gentle* and *easy* Motion, somewhat upwards, as it were with a Tendency through the *Passage* towards the *Navel*; in this Search she will find the *internal* Orifice, joining the *Passage* or *Neck* of the *Womb* more or less open, relaxed, and thinner than usual; and cautiously protruding her Fingers farther, she may possibly touch the *Crown* of the Child's Head; she will easily, by the *Sutures*, or *Opening* between the Bones of the Skull, distinguish the *Crown*: Keeping her Fingers in this Situation, *during* the Beginning, and Continuance of *strong* Pains, she will observe the *Waters* contain'd in the *Membranes* including the Child, and After-birth *forming* within the *inward* Orifice, as if

something like a Bladder *blown* , or *distended* with Water, presented to the *Touch* , dilating the *Orifice* with each *Throw* ; these Appearances presage a *speedy* and *easy* Birth.

CHAPTER VI.

Of a natural Birth, and the Office of the Midwife.

AS the *Birth* approaches, the Woman grows *hotter* and *red* in the Face; the Pains bear more *strongly* down; the *internal* Orifice *opens*; the *Vagina* or *Passage*, at its *Entrance*, becomes more swell'd, as the Child's Head advances; and the *Membranes* are more and more *tensely* stretched; before the *Birth*, the Person is often seized with a *Vomiting*, and *universal* Tremor, without the Coldness of an *Ague*; and very often a *Humour*, *discolour'd* with *Blood*, immediately preceeds the *Breach* of the *Membranes*; when these Symptoms, or several of them, become urgent, 'tis Time to put the Woman in a proper Situation, as describ'd in the preceeding Chapter: The Midwife ought by no Means to break the *Membranes*, but *encourage* the Woman now to make the best of her Pains, by *strongly bearing down*, as if going to Stool; the Midwife with her Fingers well anointed, putting them gently within the *internal* Orifice, may cautiously, by separating them, assist its *opening*, and Removing it more behind the Child's Head, thereby gradually promote its more easy Transmission, and at the same Time prevent, if necessary, the Womb from being too far protruded: After the *Waters* are *broke*, as it is called, and the *Head* of the Child comes into the *Passage*, the Midwife may lay hold on each Side of it, taking Care not to bruise it by rough Handling, and drawing it, by *Waving*

her Hands, if necessary, to loosen it, when fixed, rather than in a strait Line, assist the Birth; and if obstructed by the Shoulders in the Passage, inserting a Finger under each Arm-Pit, extricate them by the like Action.

'Tis true, it happens, tho' unobserv'd by Writers, as far as I remember, that *many* Women have no *Waters breaking away*, either before or after the Birth; whether absorbed or not, in Time of Labour, I shall not at present determine; this is called, by the Country People, a *dry* Labour, and often attended with Difficulty; however, if the *Crown* appear *forward*, the Issue may nevertheless be favourable.

The Child being born, the next Business is to tie the *Navel-string* with a *waxed* Thread, so *doubled*, as not to endanger *cutting*, about *two* Inches from the Child's Body, making another Ligature near the Body of the Mother, so far distant from the former, as may be convenient for *Cutting* between *both* Ligatures, and separating the Infant from its *After-birth*. Midwives are too apt to leave a greater Length, which can be of no Service, but has been thought, on the contrary, by our Countryman CHAPMAN, to occasion *Navel* Ruptures.

After the *Separation* of the *Navel-string*, the Care to get the *After-birth* succeeds; this will often come by the Assistance of Nature, with a gentle Motion of the Hand gradually drawing and loosening it, by the *Navel-string*: But if it adheres to the *Fund* of the *Womb*, which is frequently the Case, whether from the *Waters* being come away before the Birth or otherwise; it must cautiously be separated, and extracted by the Hand, to prevent the most mischievous and fatal Consequences.

The Assistant holding the *Navel-string* with *one* Hand, must with great Caution introduce the *other* into the *Womb*, avoiding *all Violence* to any Part in the Way, 'till she reaches the *After-birth*, some Part of which probably, being loosened, will be found more *forward* than the rest; which *taking* between her *Thumb* and *Fore-Fingers*, she must, by an easy Motion of her other Fingers, between the *Womb* and *After-birth*, gradually

separate the Parts adhering all *round*, 'till finding the whole free, before the Palm of the Hand and Fingers, she brings it intirely away; for should any Part remain, the poor Woman's Labour would still continue, and occasion *dangerous* Floodings, requiring the immediate Assistance of an able Hand, to rescue the Patient from the immediate Hazard of Death.

Sometimes when the *Womb* has discharged its *Waters*, and the *Child*, by Reason of a Defect of Pains, or otherwise, remains *long* very *forward* near the *Birth*, the *Womb* so *contracts* about the *After-birth*, as to make the *Separation* of it very difficult; in which case Assistance is requisite, from one well acquainted with the Structure of the Body; and the longer this is delay'd, the more Danger there will be of all the bad Consequences of the Retention, and Corruption of the *After-birth* in the Body.

It requires great Care to prevent the *Protrusion* of the *Womb* in some Women of a *large Pelvis*, or *Opening* between the *Bones*; or if the *After-birth* remains closely fixed, the *Womb*, in a very *open Pelvis*, may be *thrust* by the Violence of the Pains; or *drawn* out of the Body by an *unskilful* Hand, which is commonly very soon fatal to the poor Woman; and I believe happens much oftner than is apprehended, tho' industriously conceal'd, by *guilty* Midwives, under the Colour of the poor Woman's dying in Child-bed, from some other Cause. DEVENTER says, he saw a sad Spectacle at the HAGUE, the *Head* of the Child excluded to the *Shoulders* quite without the *Passage*, when Three-fourth Parts of the *Head* were conceal'd within the *Womb*, the *Crown* appearing within its *inward Orifice*†.

† See Chir. Op. Part ii. Page 32.

A much worse Case happen'd in my Neighbourhood, Sept. 23, 1749. I was call'd to a Woman, whose Child, on the 21st came unexpectedly, without the least Assistance, in the Presence of an *old* Midwife of *large* Practice; she puzzled an Hour, as I was inform'd, to bring away the *After-birth*, which closely adhered to the *Fund* of the *Womb*; while the

unfortunate Woman lay senseless, saving the Memory of being long expos'd to the Cold, when she came to herself; after which she continued in violent *Labour-like* Pains; upon Scrutiny, I found a large *Substance* in the *Pelvis*, of the Size of a Child's Head, considerably resisting my Touch; I observ'd on Trial, a Part of the Woman's Body every Way *interposed* between my Fingers and this *Substance*, by her Sensibility of my *Touch*; therefore contenting myself with giving her some palliative Medicines, and telling the Persons present, a Mole, as I thought, or Child still remain'd to come away, I for that Time, took my Leave: On the 24th, she was said to be much better; on the 29th, I was again call'd to this poor Woman, and inform'd, that upon her first going to Stool, since I had before seen her, which happen'd the same Day, the large *Substance* before-mention'd, came intirely out of her Body; to which it join'd by a thinner Substance, of some length: I now perceived it was no less than the *Womb* turned *inside out*, suspended by its *Ligaments*, and joining to the *Vagina*, but very much swell'd by the Obstruction of the circulating Humours; And an old Gentlewoman, who was present when the Child was born, inform'd me, she saw the Midwife draw this *Body* from the Woman, by the *Navel-string*, and indeed, the Impression of her *Nails*, in separating the *After-birth*, remain'd still visible at the *Bottom* of the *Womb*, and the Midwife having long expos'd the Patient, put this *inverted Womb* again into her Body.

The Condition of the Part, after so long Delay, did not admit the Possibility of rightly reinstating it; I therefore return'd it, as well as I could, into the Pelvis, and introduc'd a Pessary to retain it; and as this Person had already contracted a Hectick, I charg'd her, as she valu'd her Life, to confine herself strictly to a *cooling Milk*, or *vegetable Diet*; she has since had large Discharges of a *bloody* Corruption, with Portions of a fleshy Confidence from the Parts affected. In *April*, 1751, she told me the Discharge coming from her had long been much abated in Quantity, and what remain'd was the Whites; that she had an inward Fever, and the Piles, for which I gave her my Advice; her Complexion was chang'd from the most florid to a languishing Paleness.

My Brother, much better known in this Country, and longer practis'd in Midwifry, has been concern'd in furnishing Medicines for the Person, whose History I have given, altho' by Means of his Absence, he did not attend her on the most emergent Occasions.

I have since been call'd to the Assistance of the *old* Midwife, who attended, and she frankly told me, she had another Woman under the like Circumstance, who died the same Day.

Having related such Things as occur in the most favourable Circumstances of Travil, about which all Midwives ought to be well inform'd, and those Injuries to which Women are sometimes liable, notwithstanding the most *promising* Appearances: In the next Place I proceed to shew, what are the Symptoms preceeding *difficult* Labours, which by timely Assistance, may be secured from the most dangerous, if not fatal Consequences, and are of great Moment to be known by Midwives, as well as Matrons and Child-bearing Women, to enable them to judge when it is absolutely necessary to recommend calling that Aid, which is beyond their Capacity to give.

CHAPTER VII.

The Difficulty from the Membranes.

AN *unforeseen* Difficulty may occur, when Appearances are otherwise favourable, from the Strength of the *Membranes*, obstructing the *Birth*, and requiring great Caution to prevent; for in this Case, the Operator must break the *Membranes*, in order to promote the *Birth*; and as the *Waters*, they contain, are a Means to open the *internal Orifice*, lubricate the *Passage*, and facilitate the *Birth*; the *breaking* the *Membranes* too soon, will render the Labour more *tedious*; and should it be too long delay'd, the Patient's Misery would be *prolonged*; wherefore the Midwife must not break *them*, before the *Orifice* is sufficiently *open* to admit the Head, when she may tear them with her *Nails*, but by no Means pull them, for as they adhere to the *After-birth*, she might by that Means separate it, and bring on a Flooding.

CHAPTER VIII.

Difficulties occasion'd by the Navel-String.

THE *Navel-string*, by a Variety of Convolutions, sometimes obstructs the Birth, for being shortned, by its Contortions about the Neck, or any Part of the Body, the *Labour* will become *unnatural*, by Reason tho' the Pains are *strong*, the *Navel-string*, by its *shortness*, will pull the Child back with each Pain; and here an unskilful Management may break the String, and occasion a dangerous Flooding; but as the Woman's Pains will prove *ineffectual*, notwithstanding their Strength and Force, the Midwife will, by this Means, find the Case out of her Province; I mean, where the *Navel-string* is very much *abbreviated*.

If the *Navel-string* comes forward before the Child's Head, it will seldom remain, when put backward by the Hand; therefore, if the Midwife has any Regard for the Life of the Child, she ought to call for Assistance, before the Birth is further advanc'd, or it will be extremely difficult, if not impossible, to save the Infant; and she would probably be foil'd for want of sufficient Strength, had she Skill to save it.

CHAPTER IX.

Difficulties from the Placenta or Secundines.

THE *Placenta* or *After-birth*, being from any violent Shock or Accident, more or less, *separated* from its Seat, during any Time of Breeding, will produce a Flooding, in Proportion to its Quantity, *dangerous*, which is sometimes so violent, as to occasion Death in an Hour's Time; and nothing but *instant* Delivery can prevent it. When the Case is not so desperate, as all the *Blood* in the Mother's Body, necessary to support her own and Infant's Life, may be drain'd away, the Consequence may be equally fatal in a more lingering Way.

The 26th *Feb.* 1748, I was sent for to a Woman at MOUNTAIN-DEVEREL, within about Five Weeks of her Time, in a violent Flooding; her Midwife gave her an Opiate, which she thought check'd her Flooding, excepting that once a Week, it became very violent, for about three Weeks past; when I came, the Neighbours told me she had lost a Pail full of Blood; the poor Woman was so weak, that her Pulse were scarcely perceptible, and her Voice but a Whisper; I was unwilling to meddle, for fear she should die under my Hands, but yielded to the Importunity of her Friends: It was with great Difficulty I introduced the *Tops* of my two Fore-fingers and Thumbs into the *internal Orifice*, which I gradually dilated, 'till I could pass my

Hand, when by *turning*, I brought away a *dead* Child, depriv'd of its Nutriment by the great Loss of its *maternal* Blood; but had considerable Trouble in getting the *After-birth*, by Reason of its *Adhesion*: After Delivery, the Flooding immediately very much abated, the poor Woman reviv'd to Admiration, and I left her the next Day, as well as could be expected in so low a Circumstance, tho' dubious of her Recovery: I heard she died five or six Weeks after; but I am well satisfied, had she had an earlier Recourse for Assistance, she might have recover'd.

In these Cases, Midwives are too apt to trust to their own Judgments, instead of calling for better Assistance; and tho' they have Recourse to external *Applications*, *Ligatures*, and *Opiates*, these Things, injudiciously practis'd, are frequently more detrimental than beneficial: For Instance, should the *Arteries* be compress'd by too tight a Ligature of the *Arms* and *Legs*, the *Flooding* would become more violent.

When ignorant Midwives, by rashly pulling the *Navel-string*, break it, or by the Adhesion of the *After-birth*, find it out of their Power to bring it away, they are apt to persuade People, it will come without further Help, which seldom happens; on the Contrary it most frequently occasions Death, more or less suddenly, or Hecticks and Consumptions, when left to corrupt in the Body: The *Uterus* sometimes so strongly contracts about, and embraces it, that it may be impossible, after a few Hours Delay, to procure it, as I found in a Case that occur'd to me at COLEHORN, the 30th *Sept.* 1748, tho' little more than four Hours passed, from the Time the Midwife broke the *String* close to the *Placenta*, for the Part of the *Uterus* next the *Placenta* was so contracted, as barely to admit the *Tops* of my two Fore-fingers; I endeavour'd, with all possible Caution, to make a larger Aperture, but in the ill *Situation* of the *Uterus*, at the Extent of my Reach, all my Attempts were in Vain; this Woman rested well the succeeding Night, and had no extraordinary Complaints when I left her in the Morning, first prescribing what I thought most suitable to her Condition: I afterwards heard she died with a Frenzy, succeeding a *Suppression* of the *usual*

Purgations; where the Corruption of the *Placenta* takes Place, the Case is, at least, more Chronical, and the *Secundines* , gradually wasting, come away Piece-meal, the Patient labouring under a Hectick from the Contagion of putrid Humours, mixing with the circulating Fluids.

I have at other Times, after a longer Delay, been more successful; the 28th *December* , the same Year, I was call'd, by Order of the late Lord WEYMOUTH, to the Assistance of a poor Woman at HORNISHAM, whose *After-birth* had been retain'd three Days; she had contracted a Fever from its Putrefaction, which was so great, that scarcely any Body could bear the Room, and had lost a great deal of Blood by Flooding; the poor Woman soon recover'd after her Delivery, in the Use of a little Medicine, from his Lordship's House: I have seldom found the Business difficult, when speedily call'd in the like Cases.

CHAPTER X.

Difficulties attending the Contraction, or Ill-site of the Inward Orifice.

IN the Fifth Chapter I have told, how the Midwife may judge, by touching, of an easy Birth; carefully introducing her two Fore-fingers into the Passage, to find the internal Orifice of the Womb in the Beginning of Labour; now, in doing this, if the Orifice, she is in Search for, does not readily occur, she has great Reason to apprehend Difficulty; and if not well acquainted with the Parts she handles, by rude Usage, piercing through any Part of the *Vagina*, which presents to the *Touch*, may do Mischief. Such an Injury was done to one of Box, where I was called *Sept.* 21, 1748. This Woman had been in Labour several Days; the Midwife having, the last Time, been with her eighteen Hours, the Pole of the Child's Head lay upon the Share-bone, which was rectified by one Limb of the Extractor and brought into the Passage; the other Limb being joined, the Infant was soon born; but what before surprized me, was to find a *Passage*, for my Fingers, considerably remote from the *internal Orifice*, with great Complaints of a smarting Pain when I touch'd it; a Suppuration follow'd, but the Woman soon recover'd, after the frequent Use of an emollient and discutient Fomentation.

When the *Orifice* presents rightly, and is easily found, it is next of Consequence to observe, whether the Pains *relax*, *open* and *enlarge* it; for should it remain *thick* and *contracted*, instead of relaxing and growing thinner, if the Infant comes rightly directed, the Woman's Pains are not *genuine* but *spurious*; it will then be proper to give an emollient and carminative Glyster, and probably the false Pains will be reliev'd, and the true succeed; or some Time may intervene, before her true Labour, especially if the full Time of Breeding should not be expired.

If the Midwife cannot reach the *internal Orifice*, and the Child's Head lays *high*, the Orifice may possibly lay *high*, *backwards* or *forwards*, or more or less so, inclining *Sideways*; the Reason of which may be apprehended, from the brief Account of the *Womb*, and the *Pelvis*, in the Second Chapter. In this Case it may be with great Difficulty, the Assistant can reach the nearest Margin of the *internal Orifice*, tho' well instructed and experienced, and it will often require the Hand of an expert Artist, early in Labour to rectify it, or turn the Child, when Travil is advanced; or if too long neglected may occasion the Death of one, or both Mother and Child.

CHAPTER XI.

Difficulties attending a wrong Position of the Child's Head.

IF in the Progress of Travail, the Midwife perceives any Part of the Head, besides the *Crown*, discoverable by its *Sutures*, presenting, and it appear *broad*, and very *hard* to the *Touch*: If the *Waters* may be *felt* descending in a *long* Form through the *internal Orifice*, somewhat like a Piece of a Gut distended with Water: These Appearances presage the utmost Difficulty and Danger, commonly owing to the small Distance between the *forward* and *back* Bones; an ill Situation of the *internal Orifice*; the *comparative Largeness* of the Child's Head; or the *ill* Site of the *Womb*; whereby the Head may be pressed against the Bones *forward* or *backward*, or somewhat inclined to *either* Side, in a wrong Direction for the *Passage*. These Causes, singly or concurring, render the Case much beyond the Skill, and very often the Strength, of a Midwife to redress.

When unqualified Midwives observe the Head present to the inward Orifice, they are too apt to promise good Success, and behave with the utmost Confidence, wherein they are often egregiously mistaken; for there cannot be a more difficult Birth, than frequently happens, when any other

Part, instead of the Crown, offers; and the Misfortune is, the longer Recourse to proper Assistance is delay'd, the greater the Difficulty becomes every Moment; and the poor Woman may think herself happy, if she escapes with her Life, the Danger of a most *fatiguing* and *tedious* Labour, succeeded, perhaps, by such a Relaxation of the *Vagina* or *Passage*, as will occasion great Uneasiness in going, or being in an *upright* Posture, without the immediate Help of Medicines, both externally and internally; or wearing a *Pessary* for its Support, during Life.

Whereas 'tis certain, that if the Mother's Pains, *strongly bearing down*, the Muscles of the Belly contracting and becoming sensibly *hard* to the *Touch*, don't manifestly promote the Birth, it must needs be owing to some Obstruction beyond the Midwife's Skill; who in this Circumstance is apt to complain, the Pains are not sufficiently *strong*, 'till the poor Woman is ready to expire, from the Loss of her Strength, by her long Suffering under them; and told she must patiently wait God's Time, who in Case he miraculously interpos'd, wants not the Midwife's Assistance: And what still adds to this deplorable Calamity, 'tis likely she is put upon exerting her utmost Strength, assisted by Cordials; when *encouraging* her *Labour* and *provoking* her *Pains*, 'till the Obstructions in the Way of the *Birth* are remov'd, contribute still further to the Danger attending.

I don't deny but that in some Cases, a *tedious* Labour may be owing to a Defect of *sufficiently* strong Pains; but as this often proceeds from *Circumstances* obstructing the *Birth*, true Labour naturally takes Place, when they are remov'd; and, by a right Management of the Hand, is more *effectually* promoted, without Cordials or *forcing* Medicines, where the Pains are deficient.

Under this Sort of unnatural Birth, may very well be enumerated, the *Face* presenting *towards* the Mother's Belly, or the *Side* of the Head coming *Foremost*, for its Passage must be extreamly difficult in these Postures; as well as when the *Face* comes *forward*; for then by Reason of

the great Tumour, about the *Head*, *Face*, *Eyes*, and *Mouth*, from Lodging between the Bones, the Infant expiring in the Birth, has been often taken for a Monster. I have often been so happy, when the Head has long remain'd, wedg'd between the Bones, as to bring the Child alive, by the *Forceps*, in a few Minutes, if seasonably call'd, when the Woman in Travil has been in the utmost Danger of Death.

The 5th of *May*, 1751, I met with as bad a Case, as most of this Kind at WIGGLETON: This Woman, by the Midwife's Account, seem'd to be in *Labour* at Times near a Month, and for a Week last, almost in continual Pain, with her first Child: as I was call'd late to her Assistance, I could not judge, by early Appearances, of the Situation of the *Uterus*, or *Infant*; this is most commonly only in the Power of the Midwife to observe; her *Waters* had gradually drain'd away above a Week, and there still remain'd some Part of the *Membranes* depending like a *Gut* in the *Vagina*, the *Head* offer'd, firmly wedg'd in the *Pelvis*; the Part most obvious to the *Touch*, by its Softness and fleshy Consistence, seem'd to be the *Cheek*: The poor Woman's Pains, for some Hours, were *ineffectual* for want of Strength, her Spirits being exhausted, by a Labour so fatiguing; there was no Possibility of *turning* the Child; I endeavour'd, with some Success, to promote the *Birth*, by bearing *strongly* against the inferior Part of the *Os-sacrum*, but her Weakness, depriving me of the small Benefit of her Pains, I had for a Time; there was an absolute Necessity for a speedy Delivery, for the Mother's Sake: 'Twas with some Difficulty I overcame her Prejudice, and those Present against the Use of any Instrument, tho' at length they yielded; when introducing a *Limb* of the Extractor on each Side of the Head, and Co-operating with a small Pain, encouraging the Woman to bear down as strongly as she could, I immediately brought a Daughter, with a monstrous long Head alive.

I HAVE, however, met with some Cases, which I could relieve by no better Method, than lessening the Head; but considering for whose Benefit I am chiefly Writing, and how dangerous the Use of Instruments may be in

injudicious Hands, I rather choose to advise Women not to meddle with them, than pretend to relate the Method of using them.

CHAPTER XII.

Difficulties from other ill Positions of the Infant.

THE *Arm* or *Shoulder* presenting, is so well known to be attended with Difficulty, that few Women will attempt such Deliveries, unless they are so very ignorant, as to imagine they can bring the Child by *pulling* at an *Arm*.

As our Miscarriages, or rather Misfortunes, in Practice, may no less contribute to the Information of others, by Caution, than our Success, by Example; I shall not scruple to give a candid Relation of the most fatal Occurrence, which ever fell to my Lot.

The 12th *September*, 1748, I was called to a Woman at TROUBRIDGE, her *Matrix* lay *forward* in a *prominent Abdomen* hanging very low, the *Os-uteri Internum* lay very much *backward*, both Hands *presented* to it, this Woman had been very ill the preceeding Week, and in extreme Misery the last Twenty-four Hours; with a great deal of Trouble, I got and drew towards me one *Foot*, with the *Heel turn'd towards the Mother's Belly*; in drawing the *Infant* so far as the *Arm-pits*, I found the *Face* of the Child did not *turn* so readily as I expected towards the Mother's *Back*; as soon as I had brought the *Feet* some Distance without the *Vagina*, while I

endeavour'd to extract the Child by hold of its *Thighs*, the Midwife, unknown to me, officiously laying hold of the Infant's *Feet*, exerted her Strength at the same Time with mine; I intended to leave the *Arms* according to DEVENTER, as a Security to the more safe Transmission of the *Head*; and while our united Strength was exerted, I found the *Neck* gave way, with something of an *audible Crack*; and with some Surprise, looking about me, saw the Midwife *labouring* at the Child's *Feet*, and check'd her, as acting very rashly, without my Direction; thus we had really separated the *Spine* of the *Neck*, and the *Head* only adhering to the *Body* by the *Skin*, was with little or no Force separated from it: In passing my Hand, after a tie on the *Navel-string*, I found the *Head* fell *back* into the prominent Part of the *Abdomen*, insomuch that I could only reach the separated Part of the *Neck*, and I endeavour'd, in vain, to get hold of the *Head* by the *Crotchet*: While I was thus employ'd, a *Flooding* came on, by the Separation of the *Placenta*, which quick'ned my Endeavours, from the Apprehensions of her sudden Death, if she was not immediately deliver'd; but the poor Woman, much spent with Fatigue and Loss of Blood, begg'd I would desist, preferring Death to Life; in which being join'd by the People present, and not a little exhausted of Spirit and Strength myself, I was, much against my Will, obliged to leave her to her Fate.

Here I would observe, it appear'd the *Body* was that of a large Boy, and tho' I find GIFFARD and others made no Scruple of leaving the *Arms* of a small Child, I must join with them in advising not to bring a *large one*, without first *procuring* the *Arms*; tho' I will not say, whether the Method of delivering on one Side instead of the *Back*, the lower Part somewhat *raised* from the Bed, at the same Time *encouraging* Labour with Hopes of immediate Delivery, recommended by DEVENTER, may not occasion the Danger of leaving the *Arms*.

There are Variety of other wrong *Situations*, and *Cases* of Difficulty, which I could illustrate by Examples in my own Practice, and may be found in the Observations of MAURICEAU DE-LA-MOTTE, GIFFARD and others,

for the Information of such as practise Midwifry, that have no Relation to the Information of Midwives, either in their own Practice, or Occasions of Assistance.

CHAPTER XIII.

Of TWINS.

THE Case of *Twins* may, in many Country Places, be esteemed beyond the Skill of Women *practicing* Midwifry; but as they are not alike ignorant, and this Delivery, with a right Management, is attended with no great Difficulty, I shall describe it as plainly as I can.

If a Child comes naturally by the Force of the *Mother's* Pains, and the *After-birth* does not easily follow, the Midwife, by passing her Hand to separate its Adhesion as directed in the sixth Chapter, will readily find whether *another* Child still remains to be born, by the Appearance of other *Membranes*, including *Waters*, &c. And as where more than one is to be born, they are generally proportionably smaller, and tho' the first Child comes naturally, the second may not, she need not wait for the *Birth* of the other, by the meer Force of Nature, for this would greatly hazard the Life of the Child, and sometimes of the Mother, by a Flooding; but ought to break the *Membranes*, and search for the *Feet*, carefully preventing their being intangled with the *Navel-string*; and having got both in her Hand, draw them into the *Passage*; if the Child's *Toes* point to the *Mother's Back*, there will be no Danger of the *Chin* or *Nose* being hung on the *Bones* before, and she may draw the *Feet* forth with the rest of the *Body*, without

delaying to bring down the *Arms*, encouraging the Mother to assist in the mean Time, by *bearing down with or without Pains*.

In Case the *Child's Toes* should point to the *Mother's Belly*, the Midwife, in drawing the Child forth from the *Hips forward*, must gradually *turn* the *Belly* of the Child towards the *Mother's Back*, by the Assistance of the other Hand in the proceeding.

If the Woman be straiter, or the Child larger, than ordinary, when she has brought the Infant into the *Passage* somewhat short of the *Arm-pits*, she must, by introducing her Fingers, first over one *Shoulder*, cautiously bring down one *Arm*, and then in like Manner the *other*, and drawing the Child forward, she must make Use of both Hands to extricate the *Head*; the *Fingers* of one Hand between the *Mother's Back* and *Child's Jaws*, bearing and drawing them from the *Back-bone*, and with the Fingers of the other Hand over the *Shoulders*, and the *flat* against the *Child's Back*, draw it forth, the Mother as aforesaid assisting all the while.

Writers advise putting two Fingers into the *Child's Mouth*; but as great Injury has often been done that Way, it is much safer to bring the Child by *bearing* with the Fingers against its *Jaws*. If an *Arm* should be broke in *bringing down*, let it be spliced with thin Paste-board, and bound at its full Extent to preserve its right Shape.

In fetching an Infant by *turning*, 'tis necessary to draw its *Feet* into the *Passage*, with the *Toes situate* towards the *Infant's Belly*, for it may be extreamly difficult, if not impossible, to draw it backwards, contrary to the natural *Bent* of its *Thighs* and *Back*; and a *Limb* may sometimes as easily be pull'd off, as the Child brought to the *Birth* this Way; the Midwife must therefore make Use of the *right*, or *left* Hand in doing it, which happens to be most convenient, to the natural *bending* of the Infant's Body.

I THINK it cannot be safe for a Woman to *turn* a Child upon ether Occasions requiring it; their Strength, as well as Skill being frequently

inferior to the Task; besides, there may be great Danger of injuring the Vitals of the Mother in other Cases, especially after the Operation is unseasonably delay'd.

As each Child has a Navel-string, as well as After-birth belonging to it (tho' both *Placenta*'s are sometimes so joined as easily to be distinguished) the Care respecting the *Navel-string*, already related in the Sixth Chapter, must of Course be taken for the First-born, and its *Secundines* left, 'till after the Birth of the Second, when both, if necessary, must be separated and brought away, as there advis'd, with Regard to one alone, and the *Navel-string* of the last Infant tied after the same Manner as in the Birth of one Infant.

CHAPTER XIV.

Of a Dead Child.

A DEAD Child is often born with abundantly more Difficulty than a *living* one, for the last by its Struggles considerably promotes its own Birth; whereas, the first lies *immoveably* in the *same* Posture, without changing Situation by its own Activity.

When the Death of the Child proceeds from any *accidental* Injury, the *breeding* Woman commonly knows it, by the Perception of a *Weight* within her, in the Part where it lies, instead of its *usual* Motions, which from that Time cease, and occasion, not without Reason, a Solitude for the best Assistance.

One of my Neighbours, whom I lately deliver'd, had the Misfortune to fall flat on her Face, between the 7th and 8th Month of her Pregnancy; from which Time to that of her Labour, above three Weeks after, she had a continual Sensation of a Weight within her, without *any* of the Child's Motions, as before this Accident, although it was not succeeded by a *Flooding*, as is common upon a *partial* or *total Separation* of the *Placenta*: She had frequently been attacked with Pains resembling Travail, for above two Weeks before it came on effectually; in this Case after I had

brought the Child by *turning* , I found the Secundines extremely offensive, by Reason of their Putrefaction.

From Causes less manifest, 'tis a Thing more precarious to judge of the Infant's Death; the Woman in Travil has not perceived the *Motion* of the Child for some Days, while it was yet living; a *cadacerous* Smell is not infallible; the coming away of the Child's *Excrement* , may proceed from the *Compression* of its Abdomen in the *Birth* , especially when the *Buttocks* present; these Appearances therefore can only be a Foundation at best for *probable* Conjecture; nothing short of the Peeling of the Cuticle or Scarf-Skin of the Child upon *Touching* it, can be a *certain* Token of its Death.

CHAPTER XV.

The necessary Care of a Mother and Child.

AFTER Delivery, tis too universal a Practice to palliate the After-pains by *Opiates*, which if given beyond the Proportion, necessary to take off the Spasms attending, are mischievous, tending to obstruct the natural Cleansings, so absolutely necessary to succeed; and as these Pains cease of Course for the most Part in two or three Days, it were much better to have recourse to *Sperma Ceti* dissolv'd with the Yolk of an Egg in a Draught of Caudle, or a Linctus of Sallad Oil and Sugar, if Oil of Sweet Almonds cannot be had fresh, as often as the Pains are violent.

Particular Occasions may indeed require other Methods, but then 'tis best to be well advis'd, whether *Opiates*, or other *Medicines* are necessary. During their Purgations, the Woman, in Child-bed, ought to be kept warm, from all Danger of taking cold, to a Degree of sensible Perspiration, and if she has no Stool by the third Day, which commonly brings, with the Milk, a feverish Heat, a Kitchen Glyster ought to be given and repeated in costive Habits, as there is Occasion.

I SHALL conclude with some Things of the Care of Infants newly born; a Subject the more interesting, as our Natives are known greatly to decrease

from the free Use of Spirituous Liquors; which Loss might in some Degree be repaired by a better Care of their Offspring, who are not only expos'd to suffer by the Ignorance of Midwives, but must undergo a second Martyrdom from swadling and cramming.

Their fond Nurses greatly contribute to the general Cause of all their Distempers, *Indigestion*, frequently feeding them 'till they return it by the Mouth, which under these Circumstances, unless supply'd by a Looseness, is the only Means of their Preservation from more immediate Death.

This Overcharge of their Stomachs, producing Crudities, gives them the most excruciating Pains in their Bowels; occasioning very often Fevers and Convulsions, and yet their Cries are customarily appeas'd by more Food, furnishing an Encrease of sharp Crudities in their Bowels; and 'tis well if Syrup of Poppies, *Godfrey's Cordial*, or some other Opiate, be not given to stifle their Complaints, but in Effect to encrease the Mischief, by confining the Acrimony of an Overload within them.

Infants are born with their Stomachs and Intestines charged with the Recrements of the Humours in which they swim, before Birth, and the glandular Secretions within them, which will naturally purge away with the first Milk they draw from the Mother's Breast; and they would sleep, were they not too soon fed, 'till this Provision of Nature is ready for them, as Dr. CADOGAN found from Experience in his own Family; but as the Humour of Feeding them sooner generally obtains, and the Mother too often is not the Nurse; Half a Drachm of *Castile Soap* diffolv'd in a Spoonful or two of thin Caudle, and sweetened with Honey, would cleanse the Child, and prevent many Distempers, owing to a Retention of Impurities within them before the Birth, if given soon after.

'Tis well worth remarking, that the Food the Nurse takes communicates its Nature to the Milk, so that the Child may be intoxicated by her giving Suck too soon after strong Drink or Spirituous Liquors, by which Means

many are destroy'd; it is likewise well known, if the Nurse takes a Purge, her Milk will purge the Child.

This informs us, that when the Child is troubled with Gripes, attended with green, sour-smelling Stools, the Mother, or Nurse, by being confin'd to an Animal Diet, will, in a great Degree, prevent the Gripes, Looseness, or Convulsions, occasion'd by the Acidities of the Child's Stomach and Bowels, from the contrary Qualities communicated to her Milk. On the Contrary, a vegetable Diet will greatly relieve the same Complaints, attended with strong smelling Stools, and a Tendency to the Putrefaction of the Humours, and the Child's Spoon-meat, when any Thing is given besides the Mother's Milk, may be regulated accordingly: In the mean Time, in both Cases, these Indigestions ought to be purged off with a few Grains of Rhubarb, or double the Quantity infus'd at Night in a Spoonful of common Drink, strain'd and sweetened with Honey.

This, with a suitable and commodious Dress, leaving them Freedom for all their Motions, taking Care not to fill them with Crudities, by overcharging their Stomachs, would preserve the Health of young Children, they would then sleep away most of their Time, without those continual Cries of Misery, calling on the Compassion of all about them, whereby abundance of Trouble to their Nurses, and the continual Occasion of Medicines, to sweeten and purge away the Effects of Indigestion, would be prevented.

F I N I S .

TRANSCRIBER'S NOTE

Original spelling and grammar were generally retained. The cover image was constructed from the original title page, and is in the public domain. The following two corrections were made in conformance with the spirit of the list of [errata](#) on page vi.

[Page 9, l. 16.](#) “Pains about the Navel and Loins” was changed to “Pains about the Back, Navel and Loins”.

[Page 33, l. 12.](#) Changed “great Complaints of a smarting Pain; when I touch’d it a Suppuration” to “great Complaints of a smarting Pain when I touch’d it; a Suppuration”. This correction is not quite what the erratum on page vi recommends—but the recommendation is not quite correct.

[Page 21.](#) Changed “which happpen’d the same Day” to “which happen’d the same Day”.

[Page 49.](#) Changed “and its *Secundines* left” to “and its *Secundines* left”.

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